

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Slav and Semi-Slav

Structures, development schemes, tactical breaks, and Black's freeing play

TRAINING WORKBOOK

19 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

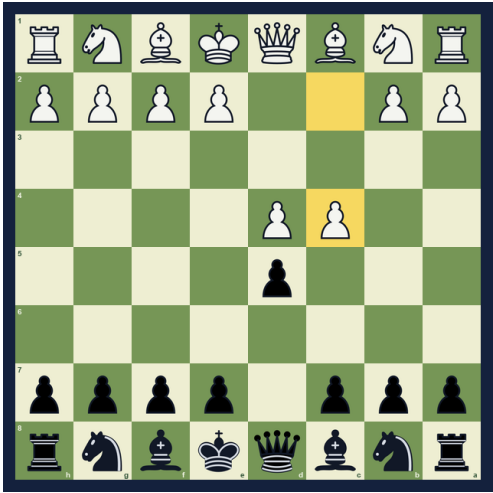
Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

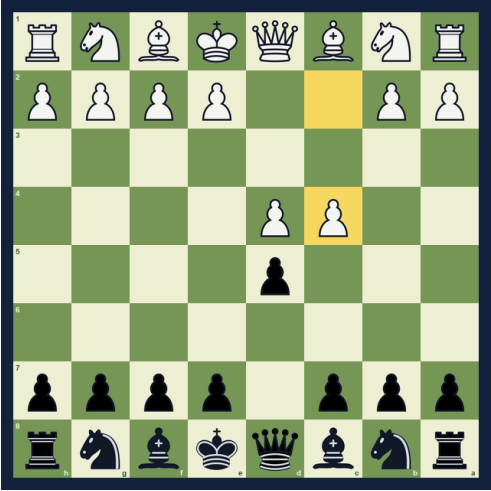
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Why the c-Pawn Is Offered



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. How White Recovers the c4 Pawn



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Do Not Rush the Central Tension



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

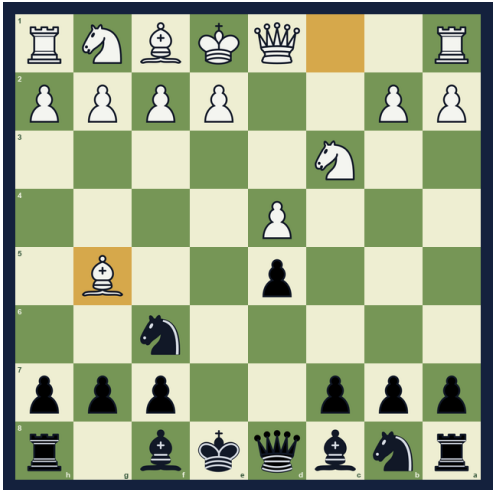
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- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. When White Plays cxd5



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. When White Plays dxc5



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

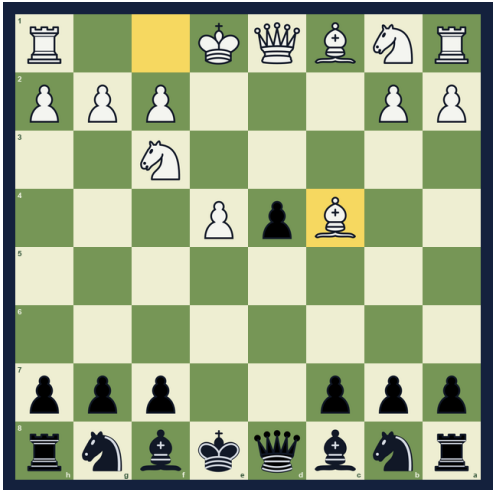
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. The e4 Break Is White's Dream



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. The Minority Attack Roadmap



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

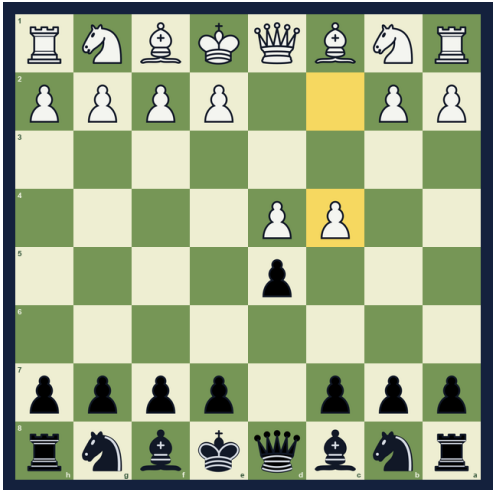
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Slav Main Line with a4



06 - Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White uses a4 to prevent Black from comfortably holding c4 with b5, then regains the pawn and develops normally.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Slav Geller Gambit Setup



06 - Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Against Na6, White uses e4 to occupy the center while Black's knight is offside, creating active piece play for the pawn structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Na6 6. e4 Bg4 7. Bxc4 e6 8. O-O Be7 9. Be3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Chebanenko Slav with a6



06 - Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Black prepares b5 with a6; White closes the queenside with c5 and uses the extra space to restrict Black's pieces.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. c5 Bf5 6. Bf4 Nbd7 7. e3 Nh5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nxg3 11. hxg3 Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

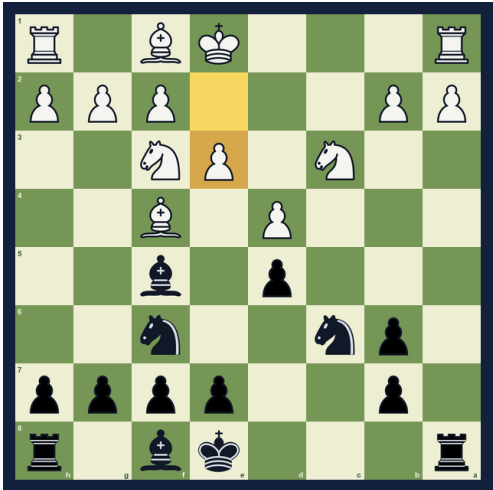
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Slav 4...Bf5 Pressure Line



06 - Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops Bf5 before e6; White exchanges the center and uses Qb3 to force structural concessions or queen exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Qb6 7. Qxb6 axb6 8. Bf4 Nc6 9. e3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Slav Early dxc4 Pawn Hold



06 - Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Black takes c4 before developing the knight and supports it with b5; White attacks the pawn chain with a4 and b3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. b3 cxb3 7. Qxb3 a6 8. Ba3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

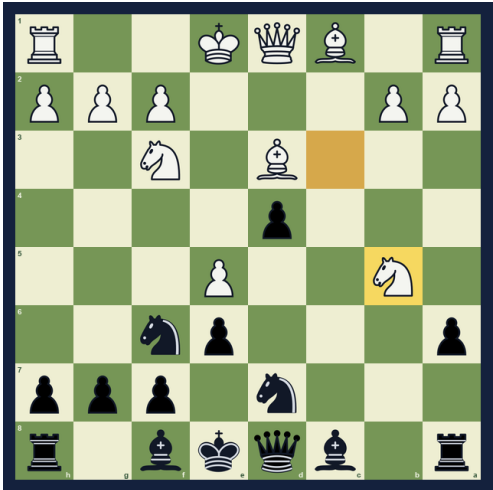
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Meran Main Line



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Anti-Meran with Qc2



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Moscow Variation



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Anti-Moscow Gambit



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.